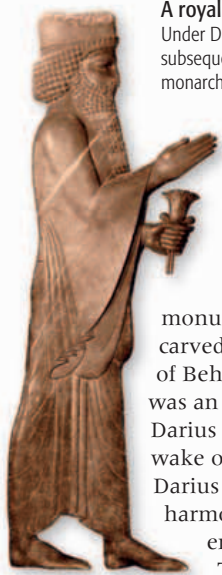


Persian Empire under Xerxes I (485–465 BCE)

By the time of Xerxes, Persian kings had annexed Egypt, many Greek communities in the Aegean, and extensive areas of central Asia, reaching the Indus and extending beyond the Oxus River. Despite retreating from Greece, Persia lost no further possessions permanently until Alexander the Great's conquests in the 330s BCE.

KEY

■ Persian Empire at its greatest extent, 480 BCE
 LYDIA Persian administrative district (satrapy)



A royal heir

Under Darius, his son Xerxes, and subsequent kings, the image of the monarch carved into the walls of their palaces remained unchanged, emphasizing the continuity of their family line. Here, a royal heir in his court robe resembles the king exactly.

monumental inscription carved into the mountain of Behistun that Bardiya was an imposter whom Darius had removed. In the wake of this upheaval, Darius tried to create a harmonious image of the empire under his rule. The architecture at his capitals of

Persepolis and Susa incorporated peaceful images of all the peoples of the empire. In a foundation document from Susa, Darius claimed that the building materials had come from far-flung corners of his realm, from India to the Ionian coast, and that many subject peoples had brought the splendid structure to completion.

Encounters with Greece

Darius and his successors emphasized harmony and productivity under their rule. Texts on the Persian kings, written

by Greeks in small states scattered across the edge of Persian territory, instead concentrate on conflict. They had a complicated relationship with their neighboring superpower. When Persian-held Greek cities on the Ionian coast revolted in the 490s BCE, Athens and Eretria sent help from mainland Greece. The Persian leaders regarded this as rebellion by an otherwise cooperative people and sent a punitive expedition in 490 BCE, and another led by Darius's son Xerxes in 480 BCE. Although some cities came to terms with the Persians immediately, other Greek states staged valiant resistance. Their acts of defiance became defining moments in Greek consciousness of their independence of rule from the East (see pp.132–33).

A world empire

Despite withdrawal from Greece, Persia continued to wield influence in the Mediterranean, both politically and culturally. The Persian throne did not come under threat until the invasion of Alexander the Great (see pp.96–97) in 334 BCE.

The peoples who offered tribute to the Persian kings reached from

Scythians of the steppe to the north, to fortresses on the frontier of Upper Egypt in the south. The range of cultures encompassed by this scope stretched from the historic, settled cities of Babylonia, where an increasingly mixed elite resided, to newly emergent kingdoms on the Caucasus frontier, who sent detachments to the Persian army and copied elements of the Persian court in their architecture and luxury objects. The difficulties of administering such a vast and varied empire were significant; even a journey between two of several royal capitals could take up to three weeks. Official royal routes, supported by regular staging posts and carefully



The Cyrus cylinder

This clay foundation document inscribed in Akkadian (see p.62–63), the traditional literary language of Babylon, gives Cyrus's carefully positive account of his conquest of the city in the 540s BCE, in which he was welcomed by the locals as a better ruler than his predecessor, the Babylonian king Nabonidus.

administered travel rations, provided a swift communication network. Across this network, orders, letters, luxury supplies and expert personnel were transported. Armies could be mustered more locally according to

need. The ruling Persians spoke their own language (Old Persian), which was recorded only in the limited royal inscriptions appearing on monuments in the cities of the empire. Official communication was in Aramaic, a *lingua franca* (common language) inherited from Assyrian administration, but only a few fragments of such parchment and papyrus documents have survived. Letters from Egypt and records from Afghanistan illustrate how movements of officials and provisions were closely supervised by local administrators, under the authority of "satraps," who were usually Persian governors appointed by and answerable to the king. Such interconnections led to unprecedented transmission of ideas, goods, and people across vast distances.

The Persian Wars between Greek city-states and the Persian Empire are seen by many as a period that defined ideas of "East" and "West." Afterward, the East would be regarded as foreign to the West, and vice versa. The Persian Empire also left more positive lasting legacies.

FALL OF AN EMPIRE

The last king of the Achaemenid dynasty, begun by Cyrus, was Darius III, who lost half of his empire to the invasion of Alexander 96–97 >>. He was apparently imprisoned and killed by his own entourage in 330 BCE. Although Alexander cut a swath through the ruling elite and burned part of Persepolis, the structure and traditions of the Persian empire exerted a huge influence on the rulers and empires who followed 98–99 >>.

AN IMPERIAL LEGACY

Apart from the practical legacy of a functioning empire, over 200 years of Achaemenid Persian rule bequeathed other ideas. **Unifying notions** in Greek and Jewish communities are linked with their experiences in the Persian empire. The Achaemenid period was a catalyst for the development of states and identities across the Middle East. **Sassanid emperors 122–23 >>** who ruled Persia centuries later identified themselves as **heirs to the Achaemenids**.

PERSIAN EMPEROR 580–529 BCE

CYRUS

Folkloric tales of fate and heroism surrounded the early life of Cyrus, the founder of the Persian Empire, and were passed on by Greek writers. In his own words, Cyrus was "King of Anshan," an old city on the Iranian Plateau. He blended architectural styles from the lands he conquered in his garden-filled capital of Pasargadae. Cyrus also adapted local ideas about kingship to cast himself as a desirable ruler in the subject cities of Babylon and Jerusalem. Both Greek and Middle Eastern sources inspired a long tradition of viewing Cyrus as an ideal king.



HOW WE KNOW

THE PALACE OF SUSU

Despite their success, the Persians left no sustained historical account of themselves. The kings did, however, leave monumental statements on their palace walls about how they had wished to be seen. Images and texts found in Darius I's palace at Susa show Darius boasting of massive excavations for a platform for his columned halls. Glazed-brick reliefs on the exterior were inspired by the palaces of Babylon (see BEFORE). They show a Persian guard in colorful court robes.

